

Nritya for Community: Bharatanatyam Classes with the Natya Collective and the South Asian Youth Collective (of the South Asian Women's Community Center)

Nritya for Community, an initiative developed by the Natya Collective, aims to make dance more accessible for all to learn. Bharatanatyam, a form of South Asian dance, can be inaccessible due to cost of classes/studio space, location of teachers, and lack of resources especially for those exploring dance as adults. Our project provided a series of dance classes to the Montreal community, in collaboration with the South Asian Women's Community Center (SAWCC). Additionally, we aim to offer local dancers an enriching opportunity to explore their passion for dance as teachers and give back to their larger communities. We hope to enable dancers to use arts as a way to connect and share knowledge.

In November, we started with a 2-day workshop to gauge interest levels and receive feedback. We had 13 people sign up for these classes which were held in the Parc Extension neighbourhood, Montreal. 3 teachers led these classes, covering the basics of Bharatanatyam and sharing aspects of the history and culture associated with it. After the workshop was over, we sent out a feedback form to determine interest in more classes. Everyone enjoyed the classes and thought the difficulty level and class format were appropriate. Additionally, everyone who responded was interested in more classes. Some feedback we received was to host the classes on the weekends and in a different studio, located more centrally.

Using this feedback, we worked with SAWCC to find a new studio to host classes during the weekends. We found a studio in downtown Montreal and began planning for a series of 6 classes in February/March. Additionally, we worked to create a group chat for attendees in order to send out the items that we worked on in the previous classes, for those who may have missed it. Using the experiences from the November workshop, we developed a curriculum with the help of established teachers in Montreal:

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1_w6e9hE8ue0otkwv5bTkIKOZOvzUQOOnZd2DyjLFRKM/edit?usp=sharing.

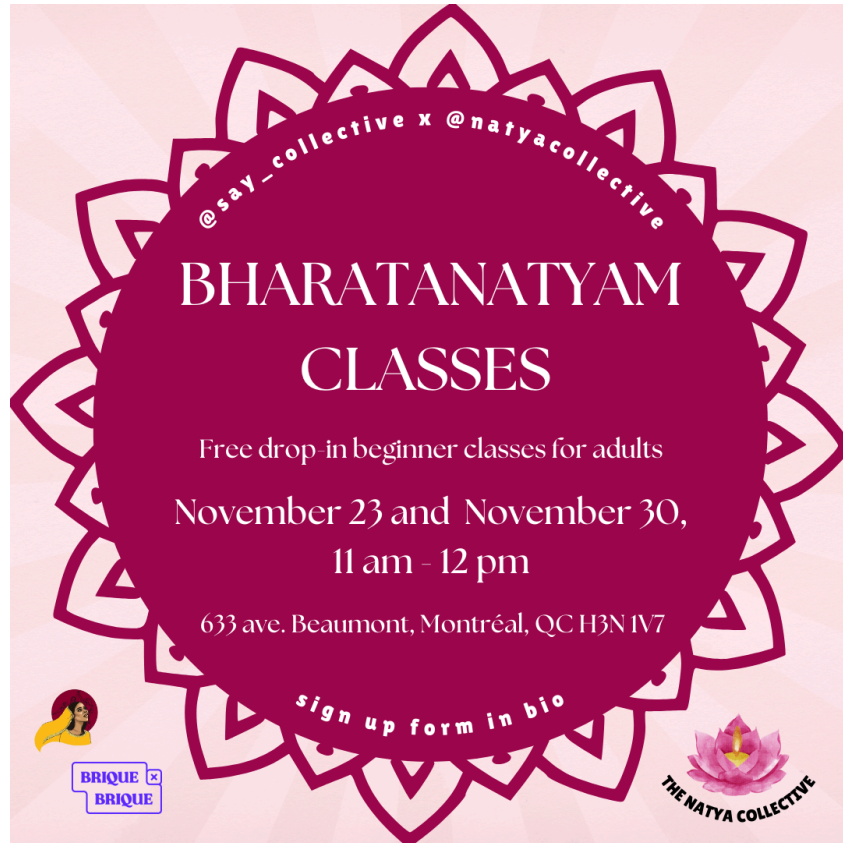
Our next dance class session had lots of interest, with classes filling up in 24 hours. We received 26 total sign ups, with about 17 people for each class. These classes were also recognized and shared by established dancers and teachers across Canada. This session also had 6 teachers who taught classes in pairs of 2. These classes were very well received and we were given good feedback each day. In these classes we continued building on the basics, working our way through a series of adavus - the basic

building blocks of Bharatanatyam dance. These classes were also a good way for students to connect with teachers if they were interested in learning more, some of our attendees reached out for us to connect them with the instructors for more classes. In our end of session feedback form, we received positive feedback on the new session of classes, with people interested in more classes in the future.

Currently, we are looking for ways to continue dance classes during the summer and into next year.

Budget:

<https://docs.google.com/document/d/1IntlKU4osKA8XifSeLLrp8m3fJAONegu3CVhleeH8jA/edit?usp=sharing>



SAY COLLECTIVE

THE NATYA COLLECTIVE

Free Beginner's Bharatanatyam Classes

SATURDAYS, 11:30 AM – 1 PM

FEBRUARY 15 – MARCH 22

**Espaces des Arts, 9 St Catherine St,
Montreal, H2X 1K3 (MET B Studio)**
 **Saint-Laurent Metro**

**Sign up with the
link in our bio!**

